

Argos and the Lost Keepsake



The windswept shores of Troy stretch along a bright Aegean sea, where wooden ships with painted eyes lie beached on the long sand and a great city of honey-coloured walls stands proud on the hill above. For a long while two camps, the weary seafarers on the beach and the proud city behind its gates, have been caught in a tired old quarrel that neither truly wants. Across the wine-dark sea lies the long road home, full of wonders: a loyal old hound, a keeper of the winds, and lonely sea-singers on the rocks. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who is clever, brave, and keeps faith with a friend. The grandest deeds are done not with spears but with a good idea and a kind heart, and the oldest quarrels often end with a single brave act of friendship.





Read aloud, or let an older child read it themselves. Pause at each question so the heroes can decide together. There are no wrong answers here, only braver ideas to try.

Before you begin

After all the long years on these shores, the ships were nearly ready at last. The whole Ship Camp hummed with happy work: sails were being patched, baskets of figs lashed down, and everyone talking of home across the wine-dark sea. The hardest day was nearly over, and a soft, glad feeling drifted along the beach with the smoke of the cook-fires.

But by one tent sat your friend Lykos, with his head in his hands. He was not hurt, and nobody had been unkind to him. He had simply lost something, and his heart was heavy with it.

"My keepsake is gone," he said when you knelt beside him. "A little token, carved from olive wood, that my grandmother pressed into my hand the morning we set sail. I have carried it all this long way, and now I have dropped it somewhere out on the windswept shore. We sail at sunset. I cannot go home and leave it behind. I just cannot."

Odysseus the Clever, captain of the seafarers, came and crouched down with you. He was the sort of man who would rather solve a problem than shout about it. "So," he said gently, "a friend is sad, and a small treasure is lost on a very long beach. That is no job for spears. That is a job for clever eyes and a faithful heart. Will you go and find it before the tide and the wind hide it for good?"

Into your hands he gave three gifts: the Conch Horn, a great spiral shell that sounds a warm calling note across the water; the Basket of Honey and Figs, in case the search grew long; and Penelope's Thread, a ball of strong weaving thread to mark your way so you could never lose it. Then he put two fingers to his lips and whistled, and up the beach, at a stiff old trot, came a grey-muzzled hound with bright, kind eyes and a tail that would not stop.

"This is Argos the Faithful Hound," said Odysseus, scratching the dog's ears. "He never forgets a friend, and he never forgets a scent. Follow his nose. Follow one another. And whatever you do, leave no one behind."



What is your hero name? Which quality will you carry: Cleverness, Courage, or Loyalty?



Argos lowered his nose to the sand and set off, and you went after him along the shining edge of the sea. He did not hurry. Every few steps he stopped at some small mark, breathed it in, and glanced back to see that you were watching too.

The beach was written all over with clues, if you only looked. Here was a footprint pressing deep where someone had stood thinking. Here was a fig, dropped and forgotten. Here was a wide scuff in the sand where a tired traveller had sat down to rest, and beyond it the footprints carried on in one clear direction.

★ *Which way did your friend walk? Will you crouch with Argos and read the tracks together, telling the marks that lead onward from the marks that lead nowhere? Argos will tell you if you are warm.*

When you chose the trail the clues pointed to, Argos gave a single bright bark, as if to say yes, *that is it*, and trotted on with his tail high. The scent was yours now, and the search had truly begun.



The trail led you in among the tide pools, those sunlit little ponds the sea leaves behind on the rocks, each one bright with shells and darting crabs. Somewhere here your friend had stopped, and the keepsake had brushed past the lip of one pool. But there were three of them, and they all glittered the same in the sun.

Beside the first pool lay a single white shell. Beside the second lay a striped shell, brown and cream. Beside the third lay a smooth grey pebble, round as an egg.

Argos snuffled carefully all along the rocks, then sat and looked at you, and you understood that he had found two clues for you to hold in your heads. The scent, he seemed to say, had passed a striped shell, and not a white one. And the scent had not lingered where the grey pebble lay.

★ *Can you keep both clues in mind at once? Not the white-shell pool, because the scent passed a striped shell. Not the pebble pool, because the scent did not stop there. So which pool is left? That is where your friend sat down to rest, and where a loose thread slipped from the hem of his cloak.*

When you pointed to the second pool, the one with the striped shell and no pebble, there it was: a thread of wool snagged on a rock, lying like a little arrow that pointed on along the shore. Argos thumped his tail against the sand. *Well thought*, his bright eyes said. *Well remembered*.



On and on the trail went, until the ships were small behind you, and it ended at a lonely dune where the wind had been busy all the long afternoon, lifting the pale sand and letting it fall. If the keepsake had dropped here, the wind had spent hours tucking it out of sight.

Argos cast about in slow, careful circles, his nose low, until all at once he stopped quite still, one paw lifted, his ears pricked up, and stared down at a single patch of sand as if he could see straight through it.



Will you trust his faithful nose? Will you kneel where he points and dig, gently and together, brushing the loose sand aside a handful at a time, watching for one warm corner of olive wood?

You swept the sand away, and there it was, a glint of carved wood waking in the sunlight. Argos finished the job himself, scooping the last of the sand free with one soft, careful paw, and then he lifted the little token up in his mouth as proud as anything and laid it, warm and whole, into your waiting hands.



You ran back along the shore with the keepsake held close and safe, the ships growing tall again ahead, Argos bounding beside you with his ears flying. And when Lykos looked up and saw what you carried, his whole face opened like the morning.

"You found it," he whispered, and then he was laughing and crying at once. "You came all that way back for it. You came back for *me*." He cradled the little olive-wood token, and then he threw his arms around Argos, who wagged so mightily he nearly toppled them both into the sand.

Odysseus the Clever watched, and there was something soft in his clever face. "A strong arm could not have done this," he said. "Only faithful hearts that would not leave a friend behind. That is the truest kind of cleverness there is, and you have it." And far out where the bright waves rolled, Thetis the Sea-Mother lifted her gentle face from the water and smiled upon you, and the sea lay calm and kind for the voyage ahead.

So the ships sailed home at sunset with every friend aboard and every treasure safe, and not one single thing, and not one single soul, was left behind on the windswept shore. Well done, heroes. Well done, good Argos. You kept faith, and you came home together.



Draw your hero

MY NAME

I AM A HERO OF

My energy



Colour one in when you spend it

My magics

draw it

My magic is _____

It can _____

draw it

My magic is _____

It can _____

draw it

My magic is _____

It can _____

What I carry

○ _____

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○ _____

My drawing

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Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.



Wits and Wonder

Story Pack

<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

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